

FREE RESOURCE

# Restaurant Pre-Opening Checklist

A stage-by-stage rundown of what to lock down before your doors open.

## 90–60 Days Before Opening

- ☐ Finalize concept, menu direction, and target guest profile
- ☐ Secure lease and confirm buildout/permit timeline
- ☐ Set preliminary budget: buildout, equipment, opening inventory, reserve
- ☐ Apply for business license, health permit, and liquor license (if applicable)
- ☐ Choose POS, accounting, and scheduling systems

## 60–30 Days Before Opening

- ☐ Finalize menu and pricing; cost out every dish
- ☐ Order kitchen equipment, smallwares, and furniture
- ☐ Begin hiring key positions: kitchen manager, FOH manager, lead line cooks
- ☐ Set up vendor accounts for food, beverage, and smallwares
- ☐ Build your accounting structure: chart of accounts, bank account, payroll provider
- ☐ Design and order signage, menus, and branded materials

## 30–14 Days Before Opening

- ☐ Complete hiring for opening team
- ☐ Schedule staff training and onboarding sessions
- ☐ Confirm health inspection date and pass walkthrough
- ☐ Test all equipment under full load (line check, dish pit, HVAC)
- ☐ Place opening inventory order
- ☐ Finalize opening hours and reservation/waitlist system

## Final 14 Days

- ☐ Run at least one full staff training and food-safety session
- ☐ Conduct a soft-open or friends-and-family service
- ☐ Walk the full guest experience end to end, front door to check-out
- ☐ Confirm marketing plan and opening-week promotion
- ☐ Do a final walkthrough of health, fire, and safety compliance
- ☐ Set day-one par levels and prep lists

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*This checklist is a general planning guide. Requirements vary by city and state — confirm permit, health, and licensing timelines with your local authorities before finalizing your schedule.*